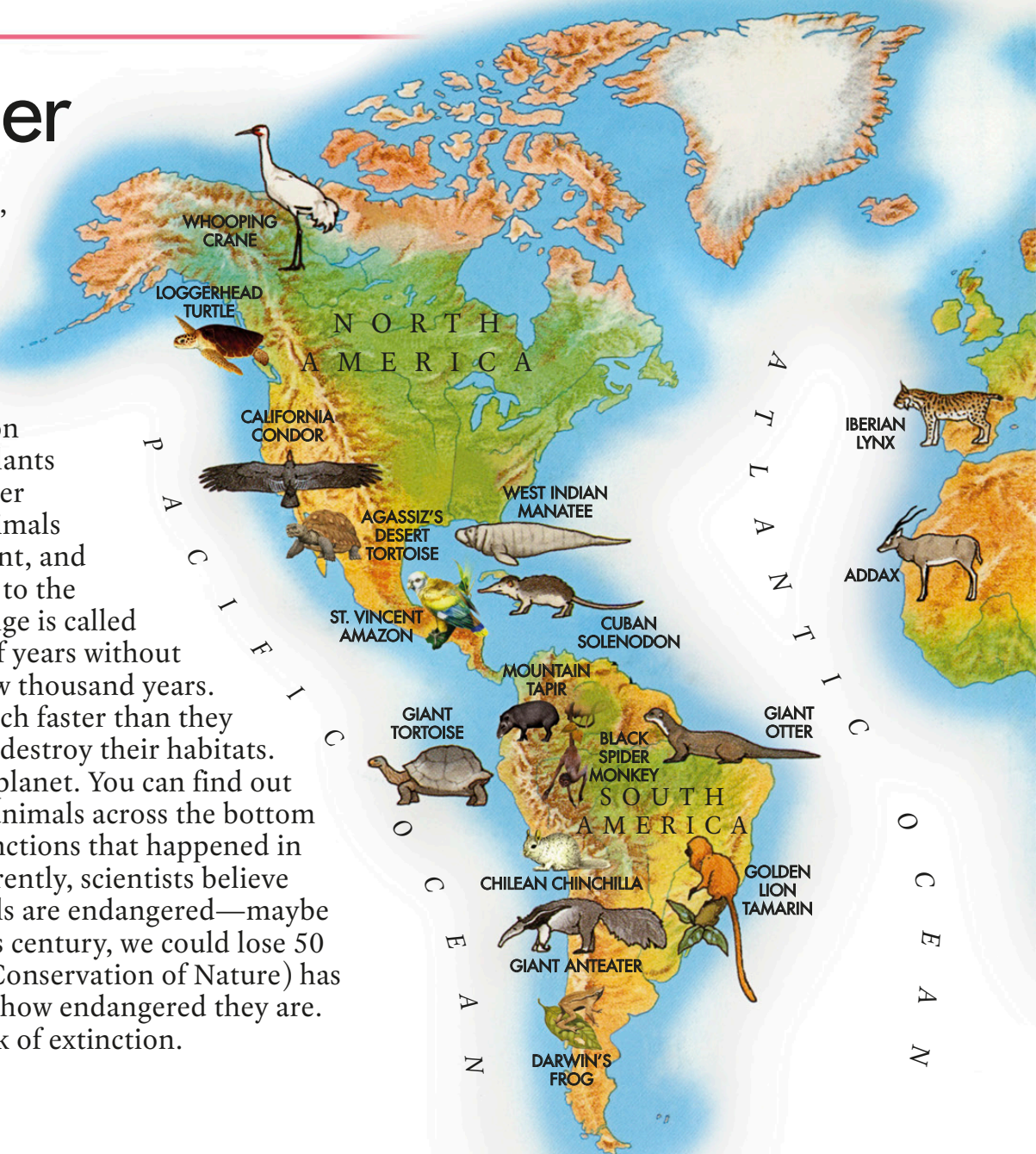


Animals in Danger

IMAGINE A WORLD WITHOUT elephants, rhinos, and giant pandas. It would be tragic if these creatures vanished forever. Animals make our world a more beautiful and interesting place to live in. We also depend on some animals for food and medicines, and for helping us grow crops and carry heavy loads.

Since life began on Earth about 4,280 million years ago, as many as 500 million species of plants and animals may have lived on our planet. Over millions of years, some of these plants and animals died out because of changes in the environment, and new species developed that were better suited to the changed conditions. This slow process of change is called evolution. Some species survive for millions of years without evolving much at all. Others die out after a few thousand years.

Nowadays, species are becoming extinct much faster than they would naturally because people hunt them or destroy their habitats. This upsets the delicate balance of life on the planet. You can find out more about some of the things that threaten animals across the bottom of these two pages. Three-quarters of the extinctions that happened in the last 300 years were caused by people. Currently, scientists believe that thousands of species of plants and animals are endangered—maybe as many as 20 percent—and by the end of this century, we could lose 50 percent. The IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature) has assessed more than 93,500 animal species for how endangered they are. Of these, almost 26,200 species are now at risk of extinction.



Iberian lynx

HABITAT DESTRUCTION

The main threat to the survival of endangered animals comes from people destroying their habitat. Each species of animal is suited to its particular surroundings and cannot usually move elsewhere if this habitat is destroyed. People have cut down forests for their timber or to make way for farms, mines, roads, and cities, endangering animals such as the Iberian lynx or gorilla that once lived there. Without trees, the soil may be washed away by the rain or blown away by the wind, creating land which is of no use to people or animals. Marshlands and swamps are drained to provide more space for the rapidly increasing human population. Hedges are dug up to make fields where farm machines can work more easily. Land may also be flooded to make reservoirs that supply cities with water or to produce electricity inside dams. In some countries, large areas have been destroyed to extract minerals or fuel from the ground.



There are probably only about 300 mountain gorillas left in central Africa. They are threatened by the destruction of their habitat.



Every minute, an area of rainforest the size of 80 hockey pitches is destroyed. At this rate, all the rainforests could disappear within the next 50 years.



Rhetenor blue morpho

HUNTING AND COLLECTING

Many animals are hunted for sport or for valuable parts of their bodies. Animals with beautiful skins, such as leopards and cheetahs, are killed so that their skins can be made into coats, shoes, or bags. Most of this killing is illegal, but as long as people are willing to pay for the goods, the trade will go on. Often animals are killed for one part of their body, such as their horns or tusks, and the rest of the body is left to rot. Rhinos, for example, are killed for their horns, which can be made into dagger handles.

In the past, many animals were taken from the wild to become part of scientific collections. Nowadays, scientists are more interested in preserving wild animals in their natural habitats. But some are still collected for medical research, or to be sold as pets. Rare butterflies, such as the rhetenor blue morpho, are endangered by butterfly collectors, while many rare birds are put at greater risk of extinction by people who collect their eggs.



Fur coats are a luxury that we can survive without, and we can now make artificial fur coats which look just like the real thing, rather than taking fur from animals.



Tiger numbers have declined, owing to poaching and destruction of their forest habitat. An illegal trade in the skin, bones, and meat continues today.